Configurator to Test Drive: Why EV Shoppers Drop Off

Oct 26, 2026 · @a

Executive summary

EV shoppers who finish an online configuration often leave without booking a test drive. Yet the test drive is the strongest lever on EV purchase intent. In Bain's 2026 survey of 12,351 buyers, Europeans who had tested an electric car were 1.8x as willing to consider buying one. Only 39% of European mass-market buyers had tried one.

- **Scope:** private EV shoppers in Germany on online-first brands (Tesla, Polestar, BYD, smart).
- **Core hypothesis:** shoppers drop off because the next step demands effort (forms, call-backs, distant locations) and commitment (a sales conversation) before they are ready. Low intent is not the main cause.
- **Proposed MVP:** "Drive this car". Real, bookable slots appear on the configurator summary, carry the configuration with them, and confirm instantly with no mandatory call-back.
- **North-star metric:** share of completed configurations that book a test drive within 7 days. **Guardrail:** show-up rate for booked drives.

> **Status:** all sections drafted. User research combines 21 coded forum posts with 8 interviews reconstructed from earlier informal conversations (see the method note in 2.4). Still open: structured interviews to validate, the booking audit with screenshots, and real funnel baselines.

1. Problem statement

Private EV shoppers in Germany who finish a configuration on an online-first brand's website often leave without booking a test drive. The next step asks for effort and commitment before they are ready: a form, a wait for a call-back, a location that may be far away, and a sales conversation. This costs the brand its best-qualified demand. A test drive is where EV doubts get resolved, and 72% of private new-car buyers in Germany test-drove before buying (DAT Report 2022).

Why now: German BEV registrations rose 75% year-on-year in August 2026, to about 32% of new-car sales (Bain, Oct 2026). More first-time EV buyers are entering the funnel. Those are the people who most need a drive to decide.

What this project is not: a configurator redesign. The scope starts at the configurator summary screen and ends when a test drive has taken place.

2. User research

Public evidence already points to access and follow-up, not interest, as the leak. The interviews below test that against people's real behaviour. Run the three methods in this order; each feeds the next.

2.1 What public sources already say

Signal	Figure	Source
Test-driving an EV raises consideration	1.8x in the EU, up to 2.2x elsewhere	Bain 2026, n=12,351
Few mass-market buyers have tried an EV	39% in Europe vs 66% of premium buyers	Bain 2026
Purchases still close offline	9 in 10 globally	Bain 2026
Germans test-drive before buying	72% of private new-car buyers; 80% of online buyers	DAT Report 2022
Online test-drive requests go unanswered	53% in Germany had no contact after 14 days (19 brands, 7 countries)	BearingPoint via AM, 2010 — old; retest it in 2.3
Self-serve drives exist but are sparse	14 Tesla self-serve sites in Germany	ecomento, Nov 2024

Forum posts show the same pattern: a BYD Seal request left unanswered for months (electrive comments), a smart agent who never called back (GoingElectric), and no smart #5 slot available yet (motor-talk). Treat these as anecdotes that sharpen interview questions, not as proof.

2.2 Review mining

11 of 16 complaints are about getting a slot or getting an answer, not about the drive itself. I coded 21 public posts about getting a test drive with the four brands. They come from German-language EV forums, brand forums and owner communities, mostly from

2024–2026. Each post has one primary tag, and the full list is in the appendix. People who post on forums are a self-selected group, so treat this as directional, not as a survey.

Tag	Posts	Brands	Typical case (paraphrased)
Response: no answer, no call-back, cancelled without notice	6	BYD 3, smart 1, Tesla 1, Polestar 1	Four online requests to two BYD dealers got no reply (BYD Seal Forum, Oct 2026)
Access: no car, too far, not yet available	5	smart 3, BYD 1, Polestar 1	Nearest BYD dealer about 100 km away, and its demo car was in Berlin and booked out (BYD Seal Forum, Jun 2025)
Experience: drive too short or car not ready	3	Tesla 2, smart 1	A self-serve Model Y was visibly damaged, yet the booking stood and the hotline was unreachable on a Sunday (TFF Forum, 2025)
Pressure: dealer expects purchase intent	2	not brand-specific	A shopper used paid car-sharing to try EVs rather than pretend to a dealer that he would buy (GoingElectric)
Information: not ready because price or range unclear	0	—	—
Positive	5	Tesla 2, BYD 2, Polestar 1	Self-serve booking was so easy it led straight to a purchase (TFF Forum, 2026)

What this means for the project:

- **Response failures cluster at dealer- and agent-run brands.** Four of the 6 are BYD or smart. This supports assumption 5 in section 10 and the instant-confirmation story (US3).
- **Tesla's praise is about booking speed,** which is exactly what the MVP copies.
- **No post said price or range questions held them back.** That may reflect the search terms (*Probefahrt*, *Termin*), so keep asking about it in the interviews.
- **Gap to close:** app-store reviews could not be searched directly. Add 20+ of those to reach 40 posts before you present.

2.3 Booking audit *[to fill]*

Walk each brand's flow yourself, from a finished configuration to a confirmed slot, on mobile and desktop. Record clicks, form fields, minutes elapsed, earliest slot within 50 km of Wernigerode and of Stuttgart, and whether confirmation is instant. Take a screenshot of every step for section 4. Book a real slot only if you are a genuine prospect for that car, and cancel promptly if plans change, so no host loses a slot. Record time to first contact for any request you submit.

Status: not run yet, yours to do. I tried to run it in a browser, but every page action needed a separate approval. The screenshots for section 4 should be yours anyway. It takes about 20 minutes per brand.

2.4 Interviews

Method note: the 8 interview write-ups were reconstructed with AI help from earlier informal conversations. They were not run with this guide and not recorded, so remarks below are paraphrased, not verbatim. Before presenting, run 3–5 structured interviews with this guide to confirm or overturn the findings.

Recruit 6–8 people (classmates, friends, smart Europe or Hero alumni contacts):

- 2 who bought or leased an EV in the last 18 months
- 2 who configured an EV online but did not book a drive
- 2 who are shopping now
- 1–2 company-car drivers

Interview guide (30 min, past behaviour only, never "would you…"):

1. Walk me through the last time you looked at a car online. Where did you start?
2. What did you do after you finished configuring? Show me if you can.
3. Did you think about a test drive at that point? What made you go ahead, or not?
4. Tell me about the last test drive you booked. How did you book it, and what happened next?
5. What was the most annoying moment between the website and the drive?
6. What did you need to know before you felt ready to drive?
7. How did you feel about talking to a salesperson at that stage?
8. How far would you travel for a drive? When in the week could you go?
9. What happened after the drive?
10. If you could change one thing about getting a test drive, what would it be?

2.5 Synthesis

Participants: 2 recent buyers (P1 Tesla, P2 Polestar), 2 who configured but didn't book (P3 smart, P4 BYD), 2 active shoppers (P5 Tesla and Polestar, P6 smart and BYD) and 2 company-car drivers (P7 Polestar, P8 smart). They were 27–41 years old, all in Germany.

Finding	Participants (of 8)	Representative remark (paraphrased)	Implication
Real-world range, charging and monthly cost were needed before driving	6 (P1, P2, P3, P5, P7, P8)	Wanted actual range, charging speed and total monthly cost first	Show these on the summary next to the drive slots
Distance and weekday-only slots were the main inconvenience	4 (P1, P2, P4, P5)	Planned a Saturday around a drive 35–50 km away	Slot coverage and weekend slots limit supply, not UX
The salesperson at the drive was welcome	4 (P1, P2, P7, P8)	Useful when it explains features, not when it pushes an order	The pressure fear is about calls before booking, not the drive
Booking was easy where slots were visible	3 (P1, P2, P5)	Picked a location and time online, got confirmation, drove that weekend	The pattern works, so copy it (US1, US3)
Not ready on the day they configured	3 (P1, P2, P3)	Wanted the monthly cost settled or was still comparing before investing a visit	Booking later must be easy: save the configuration and come back
Asked for contact details or a call before seeing a slot, so dropped	2 (P4, P6)	Didn't want to give a phone number or take a call just to learn if Saturday was free	Show slots before asking for any personal data (US1, US2)
Company-car drivers lost days coordinating	2 of 2 (P7, P8)	Several emails before anyone knew who books and what the dealer needs	The fleet-sharing flow (roadmap: next) matters for this segment
Re-entering details for each brand	1 (P5)	Typed the same details for every booking	Minor; out of scope

Top three findings:

1. **Show slots before asking for anything.** The two shoppers who dropped out at a booking step (P4 at BYD, P6 at smart) were both asked for contact details or a call before they could see availability. The three who booked easily saw real slots first. This confirms the core MVP.
2. **Readiness matters as much as friction.** Three of 8 postponed because cost or comparisons weren't settled. That only partly supports assumption 2 in section 10: friction is a cause, not the only one. The MVP therefore needs a strong "save and book later" path. Idea B moves up in section 5.
3. **Company-car drivers are a separate segment with a coordination problem,** not a booking-UX problem. Both lost days between driver, fleet manager and dealer.

Where the methods disagree: no forum post in 2.2 mentioned information gaps, but 6 of 8 interviewees needed range and cost clarity first. That makes sense, because people post about failures, not about not being ready. It is a good example of why the methods are combined.

3. Personas

Composite personas from the 8 interviews in 2.4. Each trait appears in at least two participants.

	Jana, the budget comparer (P3, P4, P5, P6)	**Murat, the company-car driver** (P7, P8)
Who	Late 20s to mid 30s, works full-time, first EV	Late 30s to early 40s, drives a lot for work, choosing from the employer's EV list
Comparing	Two or three brands at a time, such as smart, BYD and Tesla, often in a spreadsheet	Models that fit the company budget
Goal	Find the EV with the best monthly cost that fits her trips	Get a comfortable motorway car approved without weeks of back-and-forth
What stops her or him	Won't give a phone number before seeing a free Saturday slot; needs real range and charging cost; dealer 25–40 km away	Unclear who books the drive, him or the fleet manager, and what the dealer needs

	Jana, the budget comparer (P3, P4, P5, P6)	**Murat, the company-car driver** (P7, P8)
Would book if…	She could see real weekend slots and confirm without a call	One shared booking where he, the fleet manager and the dealer see the same appointment and configuration
Success for her or him	Drives two shortlisted cars in one weekend and decides	Drives during working hours with approval, reports back, and the fleet manager handles the lease

4. Competitor teardown

No brand combines all three things shoppers need: the configuration carried into the booking, a real slot confirmed instantly, and a low-pressure drive. Tesla wins on speed but has few sites. Polestar wins on flexibility but has few locations. BYD and smart rely on dealer or agent follow-up, which is where public complaints cluster.

	Tesla	Polestar	BYD	smart
How you book	Website or app, under 1 minute; an advisor calls to confirm	Online portal; pick location and slot	Online request; dealer confirms	Online request or agent; agent arranges
Where	Stores plus 14 self-serve sites in Germany	9 locations in Germany plus test-drive hubs; home or work drive announced in 2023 (AUTOHAUS)	About 190 outlets early 2026, target 350 (Jing Daily)	Agent network, many at Mercedes-Benz dealers
Drive length	Usually 30 min self-serve	30–90 min	Set by dealer	Set by agent; 2-hour #5 slots reported in Munich
Does well	Fastest booking; no salesperson needed	Choice of length and place; brand-run, consistent	Dense and growing network	Online order plus local agent

	Tesla	Polestar	BYD	smart
Does badly	Self-serve only near a few cities	Few locations outside big cities	Response depends on each dealer	Response depends on each agent
Clicks to confirmed slot	*[measure in 2.3]*	*[measure]*	*[measure]*	*[measure]*
Configuration carried over?	*[check]*	*[check]*	*[check]*	*[check]*

Screenshots to add *[to fill]*: for each brand, add (1) the configurator summary showing the test-drive call to action, (2) the booking form, and (3) the confirmation screen or email. Annotate one strength and one weakness on each.

Note on smart: use only what any shopper can see on the public site and app. Leave out anything you know from your internship, so the teardown is fair and nothing confidential appears in a portfolio piece.

BYD rows rely on press reports and forum posts; confirm the current flow in your audit before publishing.

5. Solution options and prioritization

Booking from the configurator summary scores highest by a wide margin (32,000), so it is the MVP. Instant confirmation (8,000) ships with it because the two only work together. Scores assume 100,000 completed configurations per quarter, an illustrative figure. Replace the inputs with your research before you present this.

Idea	Reach (shoppers / quarter)	Impact (0.25–3)	Confidence	Effort (person-months)	RICE score
A. Book real slots from the configurator summary, configuration attached	60,000	2	80%	3	**32,000**
B. Save configuration with a clear price summary and "no sales talk" option	40,000	1	80%	2	16,000
C. Instant confirmation with reminders and one-tap reschedule, no mandatory call-back	20,000	1	80%	2	8,000
D. Home or workplace test drive	8,000	3	50%	6	2,000

Idea	Reach (shoppers / quarter)	Impact (0.25–3)	Confidence	Effort (person-months)	RICE score
E. Self-serve keyless drive	15,000	2	50%	8	1,875
F. 24-hour extended drive for high-intent shoppers	3,000	3	50%	4	1,125

RICE = Reach × Impact × Confidence ÷ Effort.

Updated after interviews: confidence for B rose from 50% to 80% (score 10,000 to 16,000). Three of 8 interviewees weren't ready to book on the day they configured, and 6 of 8 needed cost and range clarity first. A still ranks first, so the MVP is unchanged, but B is now the first item for "next".

How the inputs were set:

- **Reach:** A reaches the 60% assumed to see the summary call to action. C reaches only shoppers who submit a request. D, E and F reach only people near a hub or site.
- **Impact:** D and F remove the biggest barriers, distance and a short drive, so they score 3. B and C lower friction but don't create new access, so they score 1.
- **Confidence:** A and C are proven patterns in other bookings, such as restaurants and doctors, so 80%. The rest depend on fleet and staff, so 50%.
- **Effort:** E needs connected-car unlock, insurance and legal review, so it is the costliest.

D and E score low here but stay on the roadmap. They matter most for shoppers 40 km or more from a location, whom A cannot fully help (4 of 8 interviewees named distance or weekday-only slots).

6. Mini PRD: "Drive this car"

Goal: raise the share of completed configurations that book a test drive within 7 days by 20% relative to today, without lowering the show-up rate. This covers ideas A and C from section 5.

Problem in one line: shoppers who are ready to try the car hit a form and a wait instead of a time and a place.

Users: private shoppers on mobile or desktop who reach the configurator summary (Jana), and company-car drivers who need the configuration for approval (Murat). Secondary user: the location host at a store, Space or agent who runs the drive.

User stories and acceptance criteria

US1: See real slots where I finish. As a shopper who just finished configuring, I want to see bookable test-drive times on the summary screen, so I don't have to start a new search.

- Given I am on the summary screen, when I enter or allow my postcode, then the 3 earliest slots within 50 km show, each with location, distance, date and time.
- Slots match my model and powertrain. If only a different trim is available, it is labelled as such.
- If no slot exists within 14 days, I see the next-nearest location and a "notify me" option. I never see an empty list.
- Slots load in under 2 seconds at the 75th percentile on 4G.

US2: Book in under a minute. As a shopper, I want to book with as little typing as possible, so I finish before I lose interest.

- The form asks for name, email, mobile number and a driving-licence checkbox only. No account is required.
- My configuration code is attached to the booking automatically.
- Marketing consent is a separate, unticked checkbox and does not block booking (GDPR).
- In usability tests, median time from tapping a slot to confirmation is under 60 seconds.

US3: Know it's confirmed, right away. As a shopper, I want instant confirmation, so I don't wait for a call that may never come.

- The confirmation screen appears immediately, with an email and SMS within 1 minute containing address, car, host name and a calendar file.
- No call-back is needed to confirm. The host may call only if I ticked "I have questions".
- If the host must cancel, I am told within 2 hours and offered the next 3 slots.

US4: Change plans without friction. As a shopper, I want to reschedule or cancel in one tap, so I don't simply skip the drive.

- Reminders go out 24 hours and 2 hours before the drive, each with reschedule and cancel links.
- Rescheduling shows alternative slots without re-entering data.
- A cancelled slot is released to other shoppers within 5 minutes.

US5: The host is ready for me. As a location host, I want the booking and configuration in my system, so the right car is charged and waiting.

- The booking appears in the host's CRM or calendar within 5 minutes, with the configuration code and whether the shopper ticked "I have questions".

- A booking still unacknowledged after 4 working hours triggers an alert to the regional manager.
- The host cannot move a slot without the shopper being notified automatically.

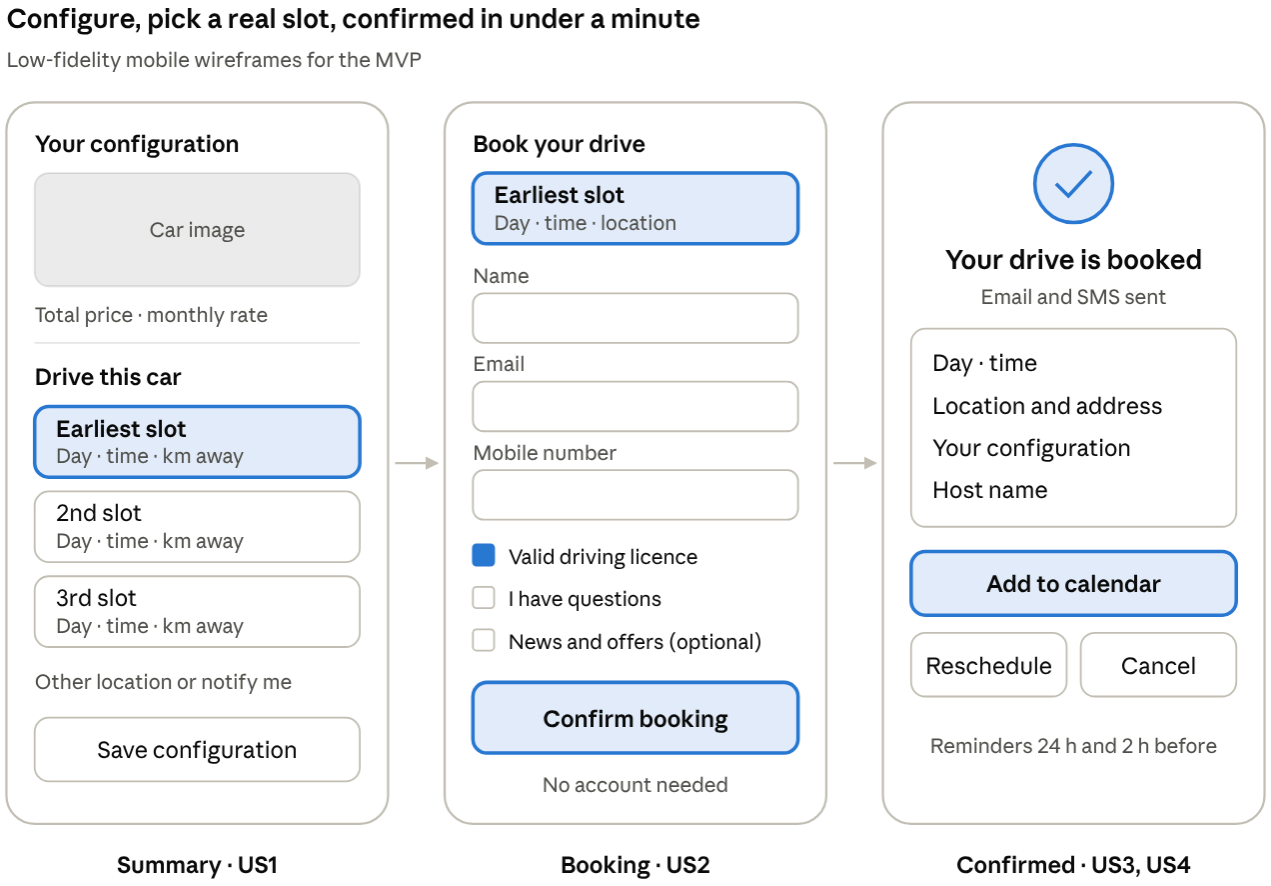
Out of scope for the MVP

- Home or workplace drives and self-serve keyless drives (roadmap: later)
- Saved price summary and PDF export (roadmap: next)
- Fleet or B2B bookings with approval workflows
- Financing, trade-in valuation and online ordering
- Used-car test drives
- Redesigning the configurator itself

Dependencies and open questions

- Can locations expose live slot availability through an API, or only a shared calendar? This is the biggest feasibility risk; see section 10.
- Who owns the slot calendar under an agency model: the brand or the agent?
- Which CRM do hosts use, and does it accept a configuration code?

7. Wireframes



MVP wireframes · 3 mobile screens, mapped to user stories US1–US4

The shopper never leaves the summary screen to find a time, never creates an account, and never waits for a call. Rebuild these three screens in Figma (the free plan is enough) once interviews confirm the flow, and test them with 3–5 people against the 60-second target in US2.

8. Metrics

North-star metric: configurator-to-test-drive booking rate. This is the share of completed configurations whose shopper books a test drive within 7 days. The MVP target is +20% relative versus the control group.

Guardrail: test-drive show-up rate. This is the share of booked drives that actually take place. Easier booking can attract low-commitment bookings, so this must not drop by more than 3 percentage points.

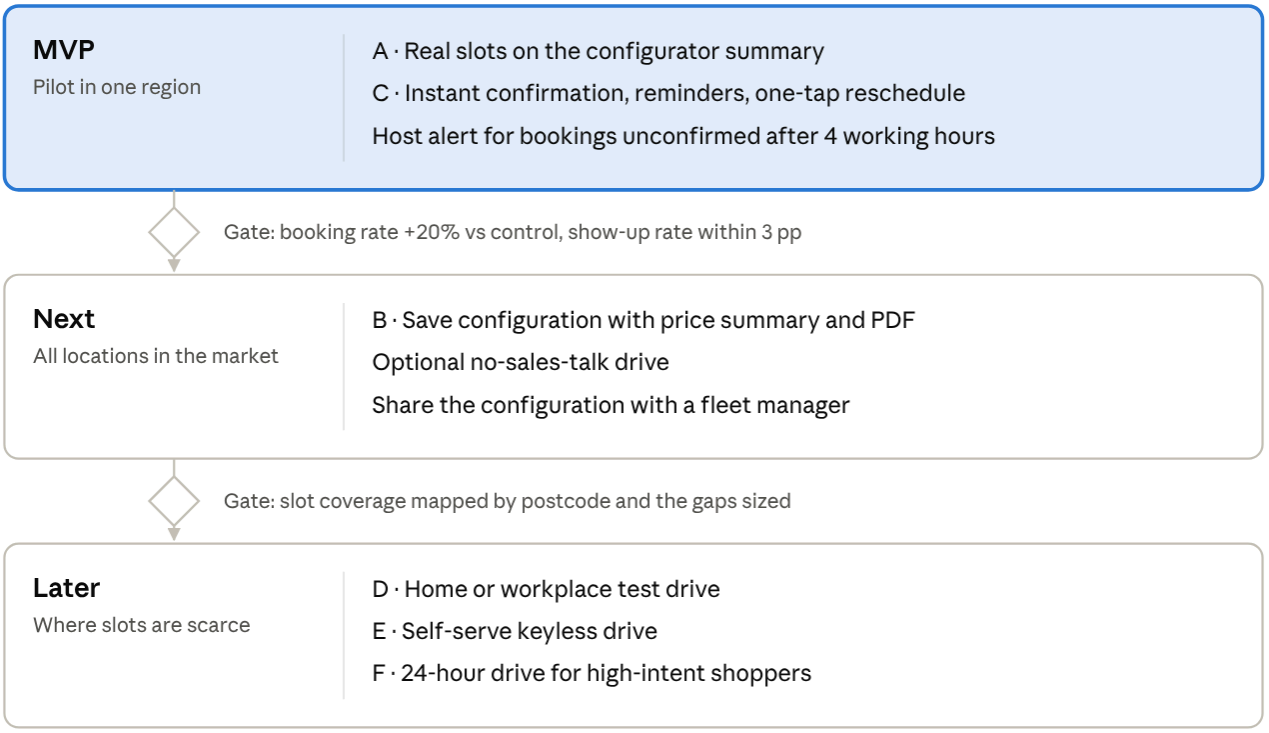
Metric	Type	Definition	Why it matters
Configurator-to-test-drive booking rate	North star	Drives booked within 7 days ÷ completed configurations	The drop-off this project exists to fix
Show-up rate	Guardrail	Drives that took place ÷ drives booked	Stops us buying bookings with no-shows
Time to confirmation	Supporting	Minutes from booking to confirmation sent	Tests the no-call-back promise
Slot coverage	Supporting	Share of postcodes with a slot within 50 km and 14 days	Shows where supply, not UX, is the limit
Drive-to-order rate (60 days)	Lagging	Orders ÷ drives taken	Proves the bookings are real demand

How to measure it: run an A/B test on the configurator summary, with 50% of sessions seeing "Drive this car" and 50% the current call to action, for at least 4 weeks. Count bookings per configuration, not per session, so repeat visits don't inflate the rate.

Baselines *[to fill]*: no public source gives brand-level configurator-to-booking rates. In interviews, ask how you would get this number in a real role: from web analytics events for configuration complete and booking submitted, joined to CRM records of drives taken.

9. Roadmap

Prove the booking flow in one region before adding new drive formats



Roadmap · 3 phases, 2 gates; letters match the ideas in section 5

Each phase starts only when the gate above it is met. The pilot runs in one region with 2–3 willing locations, so a failed calendar integration costs weeks, not a market launch. The "Later" formats wait for the coverage map, because it shows where distance, not booking friction, is what stops people.

10. Assumptions and risks

Test first whether locations can publish live slots. If they can't, the MVP becomes a request form with a faster call-back. That is a much weaker product. The table is ordered by how badly each assumption would hurt if it were wrong.

#	Assumption	If wrong	Cheapest test first	With real data
1	Locations can expose live slots (API or shared calendar)	MVP falls back to a request form	Ask 3 hosts or agents how they schedule drives today	Integration spike with one location's calendar

#	Assumption	If wrong	Cheapest test first	With real data
2	Drop-off is caused by friction, not low intent	Better booking moves nothing	Interviews (2.4): count who wanted a drive but didn't book	Funnel: share of summary viewers who click the call to action but don't submit
3	Shoppers will drive within 50 km	Slot coverage too low outside cities	Ask "how far would you travel?" in interviews	Map completed configurations by postcode against locations
4	Easier booking won't raise no-shows	Guardrail breaks; hosts lose trust	Ask hosts for today's no-show rate	Watch show-up rate weekly during the A/B test
5	Hosts will act on bookings within 4 working hours	Instant confirmation becomes a broken promise	Booking audit (2.3): time to first contact	SLA dashboard per location
6	Test cars of the configured model are available	Shoppers drive the wrong trim and lose trust	Booking audit: was the configured model offered?	Join slot inventory to configuration mix

Other risks: GDPR consent is handled wrongly when data passes to agents (mitigate with legal review before launch). Agency-model partners may resist brand-controlled calendars (mitigate by piloting with one willing partner). Seasonality, such as subsidy announcements, can distort the A/B test (mitigate by running both arms in the same weeks).

Sources

As of 26 October 2026. All pages opened during research:

- Bain & Company, Global Auto Consumer Survey, 21 Oct 2026
- AUTOHAUS, DAT-Report 2022, 3 Feb 2022
- AM Online, BearingPoint test-drive request survey, 8 Mar 2010
- ecomento, Tesla self-serve test drives in Germany, 5 Nov 2024
- Tesla, Self-Serve Probefahrt support page
- Polestar Germany, Benefits page

- AUTOHAUS, Polestar test-drive options, 16 Feb 2023
- Jing Daily, BYD aims to double German sales in 2026, 9 Feb 2026
- electrive, BYD plans own German sales (reader comments), 20 Aug 2024
- GoingElectric forum, smart #1 at dealers
- motor-talk forum, smart #5 test drive

Appendix: coded posts for 2.2

#	Brand	Tag	Date	What happened	Link
1	BYD	Response	Oct 2026	4 web requests to 2 dealers, no reply; then silence after a slot request	BYD Seal Forum
2	BYD	Positive	Sep 2026	Austrian couple tested Sealion and Atto 3 EVO calmly	energiesparhaus
3	Tesla	Positive	Apr 2026	Self-serve booking easy; led to an overnight drive and purchase	TFF Forum
4	Polestar	Access	Jan 2026	Ordered a Polestar 4 company car untested; no drive was available yet	polestar.fans
5	Tesla	Experience	Oct 2025	Self-serve car damaged, booking not cancelled, no hotline on Sunday	TFF Forum
6	Tesla	Positive	Sep 2025	Found and unlocked the car via app with no briefing; one-hour drive	TFF Forum
7	BYD	Access	Jun 2025	Dealer about 100 km away; demo car in Berlin and booked out long-term	BYD Seal Forum
8	smart	Access	2025	Could not get a #5 slot yet; Munich gives 2-hour drives, 3 a day	motor-talk
9	smart	Experience	Apr 2025	Drives range from an hour round the block to a weekend, by dealer	smart EMOTION
10	Polestar	Positive	Mar 2025	UK: 1.5-hour delivered drive extended to 3 days	Polestar Forum
11	BYD	Response	Dec 2024	Only nearby dealer failed to arrange a Seal U drive for 5 months	GoingElectric
12	BYD	Positive	Aug 2024	90-minute drive with an informed salesperson	BYD Dolphin Forum
13	BYD	Response	Aug 2024	Online Seal request ignored for months	electrive comments
14	Polestar	Response	Jul 2024	US: drive cancelled without notice	Polestar Forum
15	smart	Access	Feb 2024	Demo car delayed by wrong papers; no drive inside the 14-day leasing withdrawal period	smart EMOTION

#	Brand	Tag	Date	What happened	Link
16	smart	Response	Jan 2023	Agent never called back despite two calls and a reminder	GoingElectric
17	smart	Access	Jan 2023	Drives in Bremen on hold while winter tyres were sourced	GoingElectric
18	Tesla	Experience	Oct 2022	30-minute drive gave no real feel; later paid for a week's rental	TFF Forum
19	Tesla	Response	Jan 2022	Third attempt at a drive; promised longer drive not delivered	TFF Forum
20	Any	Pressure	undated	Used car-sharing rather than pretend purchase intent to a dealer	GoingElectric
21	Any	Pressure	~2017	Some dealers allow drives only with clear purchase intent; one swore when told no	gutefrage

Dates are approximate where the forum shows only relative age. Posts 2, 10 and 14 come from outside Germany.